

Boundaries at Work Guide

Boundary types, communication scripts, a boundary-setting process, and handling violations — establishing and maintaining healthy professional limits.

1. Boundary Types

A boundary is a clear limit on what you will and won't do, accept, or absorb at work — stated proactively, not just enforced after resentment has already built up.

Type	What It Covers	Example
Time	When you're available, and when you're genuinely off	Not answering messages after 7pm except genuine emergencies
Workload	What's actually within your role's scope	Declining a request that belongs to a different role, or renegotiating your existing workload first
Communication	How and how quickly you respond, and on what channels	Email for non-urgent items; not being expected to respond to Slack within minutes
Emotional	How much of others' emotional state you take on as your own responsibility	Listening supportively without becoming someone's default outlet for every frustration
Physical/Personal Space	Comfortable physical proximity and personal topics	Redirecting conversations that stray into uncomfortable personal territory

2. Communication Scripts

Adapt these to your own voice — the structure matters more than the exact wording.

Declining Extra Work

- *"I want to help, but I'm at capacity with [current priorities] right now. Can we look at what should move if this becomes the priority?"*
- *"That's outside what I own currently — [name] handles that area. Happy to loop them in."*

After-Hours Contact

- *"I'm offline in the evenings unless it's genuinely urgent — I'll pick this up first thing tomorrow."*
- *"I've noticed messages coming in pretty late recently — can we agree on what actually counts as urgent enough to reach me after hours?"*

Redirecting Emotional Venting

- *"That sounds really frustrating. I want to be supportive, but I'm not the right person to help you work through this — have you thought about raising it with [HR/manager/EAP]?"*
- *"I can listen for a few minutes, but I do need to get back to this deadline — can we pick this up later?"*

Pushing Back on Scope Creep

- *"This has grown beyond what we originally scoped. Can we revisit what's actually needed versus what would be nice to have?"*
- *"I can take this on, but something else will need to move — which would you like me to deprioritize?"*

3. Boundary-Setting Process

Step	What It Looks Like
Identify the specific boundary	Get precise — “I need people to stop messaging me after 6pm” is actionable; “I need better work-life balance” isn't
Communicate it early and clearly	State it proactively, before resentment builds — a boundary announced calmly lands very differently from one delivered in frustration
Expect some initial pushback as normal	People who are used to the old norm will test the new one, often without realizing they're doing it — this doesn't mean the boundary was wrong
Reinforce consistently	Hold the boundary the same way every time — an inconsistently enforced boundary teaches people it's negotiable through persistence
Revisit periodically	Some boundaries need adjusting as circumstances change — revisiting isn't the same as abandoning one under pressure

4. Handling Violations Guide

There's an important difference between someone testing an ordinary boundary and a genuine violation that requires a different response entirely.

Ordinary Boundary Testing

Someone pushes past a stated boundary, often without malice — old habits, unclear expectations, or genuine forgetting.

- Restate the boundary calmly and directly, without over-explaining or apologizing for having it
- If it happens again, name the pattern explicitly: “This is the third time this week — what’s making this hard to stick to?”
- If it continues after being named clearly, escalate to a direct, private conversation about why it keeps happening

This guide addresses ordinary workplace boundary-testing. Harassment, bullying, discrimination, or any pattern that makes you feel unsafe is a genuinely different category — not something to address with a communication script. These situations call for your organization's formal HR process, and may involve legal protections depending on your jurisdiction. If you're experiencing this, document specific incidents and dates, and raise it through your formal HR or reporting channel rather than attempting to resolve it through informal conversation alone.